the second term—depleted the party's support base in the community, party insiders say. BJP leaders believe that organisations like the PFI were forcing many moderate Muslims to either steer clear of a dialogue with the RSS or BJP, or further radicalising Muslim youth. The Enforcement Directorate (ED) probe into the CAA protests as well as the 2020 Delhi riots traced the funding for both to the organisation.

Amid the crackdown on the PFI, the Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) of the Maharashtra Police on September 29 claimed that the outfit had plans to target RSS leaders. "Radicalisation and weaponisation of Muslims is a national threat," says a top BJP leader not wishing to be named, "and many Muslim outfits realise this too." The PFI ban, he feels, will create a conducive environment to reach out to the Muslim community.

However, the credibility of any apparent saffron outreach to Muslims is hobbled by the Sangh Parivar's entrenched politics of polarisation. So even as Bhagwat, at a recent public event organised in Delhi, said the RSS would not spearhead any public movement for restoring the temples at the Gyanvapi mosque in Varanasi and Mathura's Krishna Janmabhoomi-Shahi Idgah Masjid, he did appeal to the Muslims to hand over the sites to the Hindus because of their religious significance. The RSS chief—without naming any community—also warned against "religion-based population imbalance". The Hindu right has often raised concern over the higher growth rate among Muslims, though official data suggest the community's fertility rate has dropped sharply from 4.41 in 1992-93 to 2.36 in 2019-2021. Among Hindus, the decline has been from 3.3 to 1.94 in the same period.

Meanwhile, provocative statements by party leaders, such as MP Parvesh Verma's call for an economic "boycott" of working-class Muslims during a right-wing meeting in Delhi earlier this month, continue to expose the pervasive prejudice in the BJP amid its outreach to Pasmanda Muslims.

In UP, the Yogi Adityanath-led BJP government, which in its first term came to be known for 'bulldozer politics', has decided to hold a survey of unrecognised *madrassas*. Several other BJP-ruled states plan to follow suit. Party leaders assert that moderate Muslims are supporting its effort. For instance, Maulana Arshad Madani, a veteran Sunni Muslim scholar and principal of Darul Uloom, the over 150-year-old Islamic seminary based in Deoband, has backed the action against illegally constructed *madrassas* in UP. In BJP-ruled Assam, the local authorities have razed three *madrassas* while another was demolished by locals, since August. All were being probed for alleged terror links.

Amid this row, the RSS chief in September visited a *madrassa* in Delhi besides meeting influential Muslims. But not everyone is impressed. "BJP-RSS is now doing a new drama," says Asaduddin Owaisi, AIMIM chief and MP from Hyderabad. "While the RSS chief went to a *madrassa* in Delhi," he reasons, "*madrassas* are being demolished in Assam; a survey is being done in UP." However, BJP leaders maintain that the bulldozer action targets properties of only radicals and criminal elements, irrespective of their religion.

THE BJP HAS JUST ONE MUSLIM RAJYA SABHA MEMBER AND THREE MLCs

The BJP is categorical that it will not indulge in 'minority appeasement', which it accuses the Congress and other parties of practising, and which it says has done the community more harm than good. It was the Sachar Committee Report during the Congress regime in 2006 that put the spotlight on poor socio-economic status of Indian Muslims, and sparked a debate that is still going on. "Ideologically, we don't believe in the appeasement of any community. No government scheme differentiates between beneficiaries based on their religious beliefs," says a senior BJP leader.

ELECTORAL ARITHMETIC?

But will the BJP's outreach help Muslims attain better political representation, the key to socio-economic upliftment? The community constitutes 14 per cent of India's population but accounts for just 5 per cent of the MPs—of the 793 lawmakers, only 40 are Muslims, 27 in the Lok Sabha and 13 in the Rajya Sabha. Their representation in the states also remains poor. And the BJP has contributed substantially to this deficit. Khatana is the party's sole Muslim representative in Parliament. Shahnawaz Hussain was the last Muslim Lok Sabha member from the BJP. His term ended in 2014. He is now a member of the legislative council (MLC) in Bihar. Besides him, the party has just two more Muslim MLCs, both in UP, while it has no MLA in any of the states.

In the 2019 Lok Sabha election, the BJP fielded just six Muslim candidates of a total of 482. All lost badly. By way of explanation, another top BJP leader, who is also a Union minister, offers, "The biggest reason for the party not fielding Muslim candidates or the Muslim candidates struggling to win on a BJP ticket is the lack of communication. This is beyond electoral arithmetic." He thinks it is unfair to expect that the beginning of a dialogue will lead to overnight gains. "But it will provide a platform for an exchange of various viewpoints." The party also hopes to subsume Muslims under a wider '*labharthi*' (beneficiary) votebank. Meanwhile, the doublespeak and provocative statements by some of its leaders—fringe as well as mainstream—keep the communal pot boiling, with the core Hindu votebank in mind. ■